A Comparative Analysis of Athlete Co-Ownership in Reducing the Trust Deficit of Emerging Sports Technology

Abstract

Emerging sports technologies are built around elite sports individuals as co-owners with an equity stake instead of being mere brand ambassadors. It is true that the athlete's ownership may assume a product's full commitment; however, it may also bring consumer doubts as the athlete's financial self-interest becomes more visible. Prior studies have dealt with celebrity endorsement, authenticity, entrepreneurial signaling, and adoption of technology in isolation, but only a little has been written about their integration within high-performance sports that use advanced technology. The current paper focuses on how and under what conditions joint ownership of athletes lowers or raises the consumer trust deficit related to new sports products. By employing a multiple-case qualitative study approach, the research scrutinizes WHOOP and Reliant Recovery Water, two businesses that have a co-founding athlete and which have yielded different trust results. Digital documents including social media posts, corporate statements, and interviews were the material coded on three dimensions of analysis: identity continuity and brand credibility, institutional governance, and scientific validity and Task–Technology Fit.. The athlete equity finding shows that trust is not a stand-alone issue. Athlete equity rather serves as a trust enhancer. In the case of WHOOP, on the one hand, the previous use of the product, the alignment of the athlete with the product, the joint involvement of the organizations, and the scientific justification all strengthened the credibility of the athlete's shareholding. On the other hand, Reliant Recovery Water, by showing how unsupported health claims, message inconsistency, and scientific conflict can lead to the same ownership relationship being perceived as a financial conflict and causing distrust, presents a different picture. Consequently, the research discusses that the co-ownership of athletes is most successful when real athlete involvement, institutional governance, and product validation are all working together. These findings contribute to research on athlete entrepreneurship and sports marketing while offering practical guidance for sports-technology firms designing equity-based athlete partnerships

Introduction

Traditionally, athletes used to be flat-fee endorsers who, in return for monetary payments, lent their visibility, reputation, and credibility to a product (Xu, Zhang, et al., 2026). In this specific case, the sportsman is a spokesperson, and he does not take a part in the company's long-term plans. This change has led to the creation of an Equity-for-Endorsement Model, which binds the financial and reputational interests of the athlete to the success of the new business directly. Unlike a situational endorsement, where the athlete cooperates with the brand in a temporary way, co-ownership gives him the role of both a public figure and an equity holder who has invested economically.

Such a model is especially applicable in the sphere of new sports technology and is a necessity to clear the doubts of consumers regarding product warranty, scientificity, etc., and performance value (Davis, 1989; Goodhue & Thompson, 1995). The broad range of technologies that are involved in biometric wearables, recovery systems, and data-driven training platforms also makes it complicated for consumers to establish the credibility of such technologies in advance. The endorsement deal with the athlete can bring in people, but just being visible is not a reason to forget about the doubts. The buyers need to feel that the athlete actually believes in the product and is authentically accepting a risk in using it.

The article is based on the assertion that athlete co-ownership is not the source of consumer trust. Rather, it is a form of credibility amplifier, the influence of which is largely dependent on the circumstances of the partnership. Equity increases the level of trust in the athlete's involvement when it is perceived to be in line with their established identity, when it is supported by effective organizational governance, and also when the appropriate technology that is proven to work as intended is utilized. Nonetheless, in cases where these conditions are absent, the opposite connection assesses perceived conflict, overclaiming, and product unreliability.

To separate the structural variables that lead either to success or to failure, this study employs a comparative analysis of two divergent cases: WHOOP, which is a benchmark for well-organized, scientifically substantiated technology, and Reliant Recovery Water, which is a cautionary story of governance and unverified medical claims. In this comparison, the research tries to connect how and in which case athlete co-ownership mitigates or exacerbates the trust deficit in new sports technology. Three variables are largely focused on in the examination: continuity of identity and brand image, management strategy and governance process, and scientific validity and task-technology fit.

Literature Review

1. Identity Continuity and Brand Credibility

Athlete co-ownership is able to lessen consumer skepticism only in cases where the enterprise looks coherent with the typical expression of the athlete. The Influencer Equity Transfer Model states that the personality is primary; hence, it is through convincing approval, true information, and influencer marketing that the attributes of an athleteâs personal brand migrate to a product (Dzreke & Dzreke, 2025). The personal brand's transfer is not attached solely to the image of the athlete. Cheng et al. (2024) point out that the effectiveness of an endorsement relies on the influencer-brand congruence. When the athlete's performance reflects the product's

specifications, that is, the athlete's expertise, lifestyle, and work demands, then the consumers interpret the endorsement as more sincere.

That is especially the case for sports-performance technology. Items that deal with rehabilitation, biometrics, or training data likely claim technologically advanced aspects that most buyers cannot check before purchasing. In at least some instances, the identity of the promoter serves as the primary credential. A recovery device turned into an athlete famous for disciplined training could be understood as a product developed in a manner that mirrors the athlete's philosophy. Conversely, the disparity between the athlete and the product might cause the customers to be skeptical about the collaboration.

Additional reasoning on identity continuity is found in Peterson's (2005) idea of authenticity work. Authenticity is a result of a continual process where the audience measures the conformity between the athletes' identity and their commercial behavior. The co-ownership may play a big role in strengthening this process when the athlete visibly uses the product, shares relevant experiences, and continues his or her involvement for a long period of time.

2. Organizational Involvement and Authenticity Signaling

Athlete ownership credibility also hinges on the dedication level to a great extent. Compared to those, traditional endorsements are comparatively weak, even though it is regarded as a strong signal of commitment (Xu, Zhang, et al., 2026). Therefore, consumers may interpret promotional messages as contractible, not genuine confidence. In contrast to the equity ownership relationship, the athlete connects his/her monetary and reputational outcomes to the business's long-run performance.

The theory of signaling costliness gives the reason behind this difference. Signals, which are costly to produce, are more credible than insincere actors not want to take risks. The decision of a full-fee endorsement is a relatively low-cost one because the athlete invests little capital and the deal could end with the campaign. In contrast, co-ownership is a sign of a higher cost as the athlete risks losing money, damaging his/her reputation, and gobbling up time. In the case of sports technology, athletes may also seem to put their performance credibility on the line when they publicly adopt a product into their training or recovery routines (Xu, Zhang, et al., 2026).

Yet, equity does not dismiss suspicion regarding commercial interests. Xu, Lewis, et al. (2026) conceptualize dual-valence warranting cue touches on the fact that ownership offers two contending interpretations. The athlete's opportunity to earn money brings along a bad perception of selfishness, while the quantity of the stake and involvement of the athlete produces a good view of commitment. Athlete ownership remains true to itself when the positive signal of risk and participation numbs or outweighs the doubts about commercialization.

These theories as a whole indicate that ownership should not merely be regarded as a base yes-or-no variable. A nominal equity item coupled with a limited scope of involvement could end up being not that different from a traditional endorsement. However, the long-term involvement in strategy, development, product testing, or public use serves as a stronger sign that the athlete truly supports the venture (Peterson, 2005; Xu, Lewis, et al., 2026; Xu, Zhang, et al., 2026).

3. Scientific Validity and Technology Adoption

Consumer belief in the product is an endorsement of the athlete identity and the extent of involvement as a reason, but the layperson cannot determine the proof of the technology. The Technology Acceptance Model specifies the reasons for the usage of technology due to the factors perceived utility and perceived ease of use (Davis, 1989). Through the idea of athlete co-ownership, these perceptions can be influenced so that consumers can believe that the high-performance equipment is useful and that it can be paired with an athlete's whole day. This testimonial from an athlete may eliminate doubts and promote the first trial.

However, the perceived usefulness should not be confused with the practical demonstration of the technology. Goodhue and Thompson's (1995) Task–Technology Fit model gives attention to the concept of technical matching and the use of it instead of adoption intention. Technology adds value only when it helps to carry out the necessary tasks. In sports technologies, this implies that the data have to be accurate, relevant, understandable, and directly applicable to training or recovery decisions. A wearable instrument may collect a large amount of biometric data, but it can be of little use if the athletes are unable to convert the data into changes in sleep, workload, or rehabilitation.

Thus, Task–Technology Fit creates the parameter for the impact of embodiment of athletes. Certification of the athlete may provoke customers to purchase the product, but scientific acceptance and practical utility are what ensure that trust persists. The time when the technical device functions, the product experience is the way to confirm the athlete's decision, and thus authenticity and company brand equity are both reinforced. Failure of the product to perform the promised task, on the contrary, could cause the opposite effect: the athlete becoming a source of distrust because the users might be concerned not only with the technology but also with the athlete's credibility (Davis, 1989; Goodhue & Thompson, 1995).

4. Research Gap

Existing research has generally examined influencer authenticity, entrepreneurial signaling, and technology adoption separately. Limited research explains how these mechanisms interact within a specific sector of high-stakes sports technology, where promotional trust must ultimately be supported by scientific and functional evidence. A comparison of WHOOP and Reliant Recovery Water can address this gap by examining when athlete equity functions as a genuine mechanism of trust formation and when it remains a promotional association unsupported by product validity.

Methodology

1. Analytical Framework

The study uses a three-part analysis framework to determine how the participation of athletes in sports technology drives the co-ownership of athletes in the digital innovation and trust gap. This framework, which is different from the re-examination of underlying theories of consumer psychology, isolates the three operational variables that are used to evaluate the business in this study

I. Identity Continuity and Brand Credibility

This dimension measures the correspondence of the thematic alignment of both the image and the co-owned technology of the athlete. It is a method to measure the extent to which the product behaves as a truly existing part of the athlete's life and professional expertise. In the high-stakes sports technology game, where it is hard for consumers to ascertain the veracity of the technical claims, this dimension is used to determine if the athlete's participation is indeed a real trust anchor or a disinterested commercial mismatch (Cheng et al., 2024; Dzreke & Dzreke, 2025; Peterson, 2005).

II. Organizational Involvement and Authenticity Signaling

This dimension is about the structural nature of the athlete's involvement and the controlling mechanisms the venture has in place. It points out the differences between the flat fee endorsements with little risk attached and the cost equity partnerships with high risks. It inquires whether the organization is endowed with institutional governance to manage its celebrity co-owner, which is a necessary condition for the athlete's financial risk to be perceived as an asset rather than just a profit-seeking measure (Xu, Lewis, et al., 2026; Xu, Zhang, et al., 2026).

III. Scientific Validity and Task-Technology Fit (TTF)

The last dimension gauges the empirical functionality of the product itself. It sets the limit for athlete influence by saying that even if the technology is the coolest on earth, it cannot build trust without the trust-generated brand credibility. This variable assesses if the product has data that are scientifically accurate, relevant, and applicable to the particular training or recovery tasks the consumer has to perform (Davis, 1989; Goodhue & Thompson, 1995).

2. Case Selection and Justification

The study, therefore, adopts a comparative case design focusing on WHOOP and Reliant Recovery Water, as these two ventures are both similar enough to be analyzed together while being completely dissimilar in terms of trust outcomes. Both are sports-performance products that are marketed through elite athlete co-owners, are associated with recovery or physical performance, and must be used by consumers to assess product claims that are independent and therefore difficult to verify. Thus, in each case, the athlete is, as a result, the primary credibility signal for an unfamiliar or technically complex product.

The cases also put the athlete's credibility under similar circumstances. WHOOP is the offshoot of prominent sportsmen like Cristiano Ronaldo, Michael Phelps, and Patrick Mahomes using the biometric data during their training and recovery to present how it would be useful to others. Likewise, Reliant attached itself to NFL quarterback Russell Wilson to benefit from the connection between the functional beverage and athletic recovery. In both cases, expert athletes, as a result, add credibility to consumers that the product functions according to the effects of the athlete. Therefore, the fundamental difference is not the mere presence of athlete credibility but rather, through identity continuity, organizational governance, and scientific evidence, the effectiveness that credibility is endowed.

Additionally, the cases illustrate contrary results in the trust area. WHOOP is a successful example of how athlete ownership can be delivered with product use, loyalty structure, and the surety of trust given by external scientific validation. On the other side, Reliant Recovery Water is depicted in a different scenario where the athlete ownership became identified with non-evidence-based medical claims, inconsistent organizational communication, and scientific critique. Instead of inquiring if the athlete ownership is, the study aims to find the answer as to why the same principal ownership mechanism can be used to bolster confidence in one instance and exacerbate suspicion in the other.

3. Data Collection

In order to realize the comparative case study of WHOOP and Reliant Recovery Water, the study performed a tailored digital archive retrieval protocol. The data collection was centered around the historical social media posts, official public statements, press releases, and audience reaction

metrics. The choice of a secondary data approach was justified because it presented a simultaneous way of expressing and receiving information regarding athlete co-ownership claims.

The data collection primarily targeted digital platforms where athlete-driven marketing and public discourse meet, such as Twitter/X, Instagram, Facebook, and public discussion sites like Reddit. Beyond social media, the search also included contemporary news articles, published interviews, and official company statements that were released at the same time.

To make sure that the search results were relevant to the study's tripartite analytical framework, the retrieval protocol was arranged in a case-specific manner and had distinct search criteria:

Case 1: WHOOP (Biometric Wearable): The search focused on identifying public interactions between the brand and its high-profile equity partners (e.g., LeBron James, Patrick Mahomes, Kevin Durant, Michael Phelps, and Cristiano Ronaldo). Target data included:

- Social media posts from these athletes explicitly discussing their financial equity or demonstrating authentic, screenless biometric data usage (e.g., sharing strain, recovery, or sleep scores).
- Official WHOOP press releases and brand posts announcing funding rounds, investor partnerships, or empirical scientific validations.
- Representative user and fan comments reacting to both the athlete co-ownership announcements and the brand's scientific claims to measure consumer trust.

Case 2: Reliant Recovery Water (Specialty Beverage): The search was bounded around the critical timeline of August 2015, capturing the controversy surrounding celebrity co-owner Russell Wilson. Target data included:

- Wilson’s social media posts and direct quotes from his August 2015 Rolling Stone interview, specifically focusing on his claims that the functional beverage healed head injuries or prevented concussions.
- Subsequent public, media, and fan reactions on platforms like Twitter/X and Reddit, particularly capturing skepticism, mockery, and the framing of the product as "snake oil."
- Official statements and crisis communications released by Reliant Recovery Water's corporate relations team, rebuttals from the company's medical board (e.g., Dr. Emily Cooper), and relevant regulatory context (such as FDA warnings regarding concussion claims).

Once recognized, the qualitative data was removed and aligned to the structured coding matrix that is structured. To keep the empirical rigor intact, the original sources in exact direct quotes were preserved together with the approximate publication dates. Every artifact was given a preliminary descriptive code, which was then organized into one of the three analytical dimensions. The matrix for this organization enabled the raw digital artifacts to be arranged in an

unbiased but direct fashion to the three analytical dimensions of the study: brand authenticity, institutional governance (or the lack thereof), and scientific validity.

Findings

The coding matrix systematically arranged every digital artifact by the case, source, date, speaker or account, direct quote or content summary, and thematic code. The first set of codes was in line with the indicators given in the analytical framework: Identity Continuity; visual congruence, language tone, and ownership transparency; Institutional Governance; message synchronization and crisis management; and Scientific Validity; claim type, data visibility, and ethical boundaries. The denominated codes were then combined under the three analytical dimensions of the study. In the two cases, WHOOP consistently produced codes with prior use, authentic integration, coordinated involvement, observable data, and scientific substantiation, while Reliant produced codes linked to medical overclaiming, message conflict, scientific contradiction, and negative public reaction.

1. Identity Continuity and Brand Credibility

In the Identity Continuity aspect, WHOOP artifacts were persistently classified around ownership plus prior use, athlete identity and personal testimony, authentic product integration, and trust transfer. In WHOOP's announcement of an investment on May 13, 2024, the name of the investor who was associated with it appeared to be Cristiano Ronaldo, who had already worn the product for nearly two years. This was coded as "ownership plus prior use" as the equity relationship seemed to formalize an existing product relationship instead of creating a new promotional behavior. The statement made by Ronaldo that WHOOP had a "transformative impact" on his life, which further associated personal belongings with his performance identity.

A similar trend was reflected in the social media communication of Michael Phelps. In one of his posts dated August 2022, Phelps specifically said that WHOOP was the one that helped him best optimize "sleep and recovery for peak performance." By doing so, instead of making a general lifestyle claim, the athlete identified a specific performance function, with the result being the code "authentic product integration." During Euro 2024, WHOOP managed to attach Ronaldo's heart-rate pattern, which was given from Portugal's penalty shootout against Slovenia, to the athlete's performance in the match. The fan responses, which said "Shows why he's one of the best!!", were coded as "trust transfer," where the audiences were able to interpret the biometric data through Ronaldo's performance as being that of an elite athlete.

Conversely, Reliant formed a dissimilar coding pattern. Statements attributed to Russell Wilson in August 2015 were identified as "causal medical implication" and "investor claim amplified

through social media." Initially, he mentioned that he "banged [his] head" during the NFC Championship game and was fine the next day because "It was the water." After that, Wilson made a post on Recovery Water's social media page claiming that "NanoBubbles" had helped him prevent getting a concussion using "me." The fact that he was an investor in the first place made the given statement particularly serious because, on the one hand, he was supplying the product and on the other hand, he was telling people that he had an economic reward from it.

The viewer's side reinforced the message further. Responses on Reddit were categorically assigned to "snake oil framing" and "disclosure does not cure overclaiming." Readers specifically noticed the interest in the product when a user suggested that he should just confess, saying: "I invested in the drink." Other users debated whether the pseudoscientific case and his credibility were related or whether any of these implications were then neutrally semantic to think about. Therefore, the coded omissions testify that transparency of ownership had not in this case resulted in the showing of authenticity. As far as WHOOP is concerned, the very fact of owning it is what reinstates the pre-existing relationship between the athlete and the product; on the other hand, for Reliant the answer is different, as they claim that the actual financial motivations lead to the audience's interpretation of unsupported claims as being financially motivated.

2. Organizational Strategy and Institutional Governance

The coding of governance demonstrated a striking difference. WHOOP's promotional tools in an official partnership were coded as "governance and operational involvement" as athlete ownership was indicated to go far beyond mere promotion. The company announced that Ronaldo would be involved in product development and that data-driven insights would be used, while other athletes like Patrick Mahomes, Michael Phelps, Eli Manning, and Rory McIlroy were disclosed to the public as ambassador-investors. These examples exemplified that athlete equity was part of a larger organizational strategy.

Nonetheless, WHOOP's application of Ronaldo's Euro 2024 heart-rate data also indicated the prevalence of governance tensions. The previous sponsorship executive, Ricardo Fort, described the post as potential "ambush marketing" since WHOOP was not recognized as an official UEFA sponsor. This artifact was tagged as "institutional-governance tension." Thus, it cannot be concluded that WHOOP's governance was completely risk-free. Nevertheless, the research highlights that the usage of authentic athlete data can both enhance credibility and raise questions about the rights of sponsorship, event control, and commercial exploitation.

Reliant had a more catastrophic breakdown. They produced three contrasting codes: "visible governance failure," "corporate retreat," and "lack of message control." As per Wilson's

statements, the company accepted that it was unaware of his comments and had not given them prior approval. The agent of Wilson, Mark Rodgers, tried to restrict the claim by stating, "We're not saying we have real medical proof," but Wilson instantly disagreed with him: "I know it works." The company later on separated itself from concussion-related claims and began to promote "functional hydration."

Corporate communication also manifested this mistrust. Reliant insisted that it had no knowledge of Wilson's interview comments prior to publication and redirected questions to his management. Additionally, the company changed its expression from the possibility of helping "physical recovery from injury" to the narrower sound of "functional hydration." These artifacts were therefore tagged as a lack of message control and corporate retreat, as the athlete-owner, agent, and the company provided different frames for the product's capabilities. Thus, the cross-case pattern strongly indicates that the alignment of equity is not adequate in the absence of institutional mechanisms that would connect athlete communication with corporate and scientific messaging.

3. Scientific Validity and Task–Technology Fit

Through claim type, visibility of empirical data, and ethical or regulatory boundaries, the Scientific Validity dimension was going to be coded. WHOOP came up with codes such as "observable biometric proof," "scientific substantiation," "independent-evidence qualification," and "consumer trust is conditional." Set during Euro 2024, WHOOP displayed Ronaldo's actual heart-rate pattern and not just testimonial language. The central claims of the product were linked to a CQUniversity study that compared WHOOP with reference measures of ECG and polysomnography. Under the set conditions, WHOOP stated the heart-rate accuracy was approximately 99.7% and 99% HRV accuracy.

What is more, the coding matrix recorded limitations rather than exhibiting scientific support as the only proof. The peer-reviewed study was marked as "independent-evidence qualification" since it endorsed the measurements and the specific device generation only under the specified conditions and did not suggest every recovery recommendation or performance outcome. The same applies to long-term Reddit threads, which were coded as "consumer trust is conditional." Users who followed up on WHOOP did so depending on the cost, optimal performance, and if it shared useful training on how to use the product. These artifacts support the Task–Technology Fit approach interpretation that athlete credibility might influence the interest, whereas the technology's sustainability would depend on the actual consumer's task usefulness.

The codes "internal scientific contradiction," "public-health risk," and "regulatory boundary" indicated the reverse tendency for Reliant. Emily Cooper, M.D., a sports medicine physician and the primary author of a report the company had commissioned, said that the available beverage

research did not support Wilson's claims about recovery from head injury. Concussion specialists, namely Chris Nowinski and Robert Stern, also cautioned that such observations might lead to false hope or confusion among athletes.

As far as the scientific evidence is concerned, WHOOP's claims have consistently been associated with measurable biometric functions and independently testable outcomes, unlike Reliant's athlete-owner, who added a recovery beverage to an unsupported neurological function. The difference illustrates that the athlete ownership trust effect is founded ultimately on the truthfulness of the promoted claim and its correspondence with the task the product can reasonably do.

Discussion

Statistically, the data indicates that collective ownership by athletes can minimize the lack of trust, but this is only possible under the simultaneous operation of three independent conditions. First and foremost, the ownership needs to exhibit the principle of identity continuity. To illustrate, the athlete should have previous dealings with the product, and it should only make claims that pertain to aspects of the athlete that the athlete directly knows about. Demonstrating the previous points leads to the second condition. The terms of the relationship must be mediated by a synergized communication system and a common scientific review that is based on competition data. מתקשר Thirdly, the innovation must have the lifespan of an independent instrument and should be used for the purpose that it has been advertised for originally.

This indicates that it is possible that the three factors have different levels of importance. It looks like identity continuity is the main factor that influences consumers' initial understanding of athlete ownership as being authentic or commercially made; on the other hand, scientific validity is the main factor that establishes the basic premise on which this trust can be sustained. Governance is the crucial factor that regulates the process of conveying athlete credibility and the product evidence. Conversely, a few or localized governance problems may be augmented by the athlete-product immediacy and the technology\'s related credibility. WHOOP’s Euro 2024 controversy was an incident that revolved around commercialization and event rights rather than being proof that the underlying biometric technology was invalid. Reliant’s governance failure had a more terrible impact since it was the reason why Wilson made a claim that went beyond the available evidence, and further organizational weakness amplified the issue of scientific validity.

Based on the lack of sufficient scientific evidence to that effect, it seems that the most significant factor that athlete equity can develop on the trust sustainability issue is the scientific validity. The Technology Acceptance Model and Task-Technology Fit framework lay down a scenario where the athlete's participation can positively impact the product's initial adoption, but continued usage

is conditional upon the product's efficiency in handling a useful and proper task (Davis, 1989; Goodhue & Thompson, 1995). Despite the fact that WHOOP's biometric functionalities were primarily driven by practical metrics and existing validation documents, some long-term users still assessed the product based on other aspects including price, stability, and practicality. Nonetheless, the company Reliant integrated a recovery beverage in the concussion prevention realm-a cognitive task that was not endorsed by the research tied to the product. The difficulty in resolving the accompanying scientific inconsistency was not remedied by Wilson's athletes' endorsement or monetary sponsorship.

Athlete equity should be seen not as an independent source of credibility but as a credibility amplifier. In the case of WHOOP, it amplified prior use, performance relevance, organizational structure, biometric evidence, and scientific testing to allow ownership to be a trust anchor. In the case of Reliant, it amplified financial conflict, expertise mismatch, organizational problems, scientific limitation, and health risk, which led to ownership being a credibility trap. Thus, the co-ownership of an athlete with an athlete who is truly engaged and a competent technology as the basis of trust, while governance protects and coordinates these signals, is the best.

Conclusion

The current research focused on the mechanisms and the settings in which athlete co-ownership can effectively address the trust deficit in sports technology. The juxtaposition of WHOOP and Reliant Recovery Water shows that only equity ownership is not adequate to make athlete promotion believable. Rather, the impact depends on the cues regarding the collaboration. Evidence shows that a consumer who is persuaded by an athlete endorsing a product has a higher effective perception of the partnership due to a proper alignment of the athlete and the product, along with the availability of scientific evidence that is complementary to the organizational involvement. Conversely, Reliant exemplifies how athletes' statements that are beyond the scientific evidence, together with organizational failure, can worsen consumer skepticism. Thus, athlete equity mainly acts as a credibility amplifier, i.e., it promotes either trust or distrust depending on the quality of the partnership and product behind.

The data gathered in this research, therefore, imply that beyond just the choice of a well-known athlete or offering a share of equity, the mistake of athlete co-ownership is a failure of the sports-technology firms. The athlete-product relationship should be real and scientifically justifiable, while institutional governance is employed as a way to guard and coordinate those signals. More broadly, this study shows that as athletes are increasingly becoming investors and co-owners, they should be assessed on their commercial road not only by the visibility or the financial value they provide, but by the extent to which the technology they endorse is credible. Future research may examine these relationships in the context of a larger collection of

athlete-owned businesses to see if the trends discovered in WHOOP and Reliant hold across other types of sports technology.

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Appendix

Appendix A. Coding Framework / Codebook

Analytical Dimension	Indicators	Guiding Questions for Analysis
1. Identity Continuity	Visual congruence, language tone, transparency	Is the athlete physically using the product in a natural setting? Does the caption use authentic language or read like a corporate script? Is their equity stake transparently disclosed (e.g., "Proud investor")?
2. Institutional Governance	Brand tagging, crisis management, synchronization	Does the athlete's post align perfectly with the brand's official messaging? During the Reliant backlash, did the official brand account contradict the athlete? Are scientific institutions tagged alongside the athlete?
3. Scientific Validity	Claim types, data visibility, ethical boundaries	Does the post make predictive performance claims (WHOOP) or medical healing claims (Reliant)? Are actual data metrics visibly shown in the post? Does the language trigger regulatory red flags (e.g., "cure," "prevent")?

Appendix B. WHOOP Coding Artifacts

Case	Source	Date	Speaker (Account)	Direct Quote or Content Summary	Theme

WHOOP	Official WHOOP press release	Oct. 28, 2020	WHOOP	WHOOP's $100 million Series E announcement identified Kevin Durant through ThirtyFive Ventures, Patrick Mahomes, Larry Fitzgerald, Eli Manning, Rory McIlroy, and Justin Thomas as professional-athlete investors. (WHOOP)	Equity-for-endorsement foundation. The athletes were disclosed as investors rather than merely paid endorsers, creating a stronger financial and reputational alignment with the product.
WHOOP	X/Twitter — original WHOOP post	May 13, 2024	@WHOOP	"BREAKING: Cristiano Ronaldo is now an investor and global ambassador for @WHOOP." The post added that he had already worn the product for approximately two years. (X (formerly Twitter))	Ownership plus prior use. WHOOP framed the investment as the formalization of an existing product relationship, supporting authenticity rather than a newly manufactured endorsement.
WHOOP	WHOOP/Business Wire announcement; Instagram Live launch	May 13, 2024	Cristiano Ronaldo	"WHOOP has had a transformative impact on my life both on and off the pitch, and I'm honored to join the team as an investor." (Business Wire)	Athlete identity and personal testimony. Ronaldo connected ownership directly to his training philosophy and long-term performance identity.

WHOOP	Official partnership announcement	May 13, 2024	WHOOP / Will Ahmed	WHOOP said Ronaldo had been a member for years and would participate in product development and the use of data-driven insights. The announcement also identified Mahomes, Phelps, Manning, and McIlroy as “global ambassador investors.” (Business Wire)	Governance and operational involvement. The relationship was presented as extending beyond publicity into product feedback and data interpretation.
WHOOP	Instagram — Michael Phelps	Aug. 27, 2022, approx.	@m_phelps00	“Tune in tomorrow to watch @justinthomas34 and me discuss how WHOOP helps us optimize our sleep and recovery for peak performance.” (Instagram)	Authentic product integration. Phelps described a specific performance use—sleep and recovery—rather than making a generic lifestyle endorsement.
WHOOP	Instagram/X — WHOOP match-data post	July 2, 2024	WHOOP / Cristiano Ronaldo data	WHOOP published Ronaldo’s heart-rate pattern during Portugal’s penalty shootout against Slovenia, asserting that he entered a “flow state” and lowered his heart rate before taking his penalty. (Instagram)	Observable biometric proof. Real competition data made the athlete-product relationship appear demonstrable and personally consequential, not merely symbolic.

WHOOP	Social-media reactions quoted in sports coverage	July 2–4, 2024	Football fans	Representative replies included “Shows why he’s one of the best!!”, “Legend,” and “That’s why he’s the best in pressure situations.” (The Irish Sun)	Trust transfer. Fans interpreted the physiological data through Ronaldo’s established identity as an unusually composed, elite performer.
WHOOP	Sponsorship-industry reaction on X	July 4, 2024	Ricardo Fort, former global sponsorship executive	Fort argued that publishing branded WHOOP data from a UEFA match constituted unauthorized “ambush marketing” because it connected the product to the tournament without official sponsorship rights. (The Irish Sun)	Institutional-governance tension. Authentic athlete data enhanced credibility but also created questions about competition rules, event ownership, and brand control.
WHOOP	Official WHOOP scientific-validation article	Oct. 27, 2022	WHOOP	WHOOP promoted findings of 99.7% heart-rate accuracy and 99% HRV accuracy, based on a CQUniversity study funded by the Australian Institute of Sport. The devices were compared with ECG and polysomnography measurements. (WHOOP)	Scientific substantiation. Unlike an unsupported testimonial, WHOOP connected its performance claims to defined metrics, comparators, and a published validation study.

WHOOP	*Sensors* peer-reviewed study	Aug. 2022	Researchers at CQUniversity and collaborating institutions	The laboratory study compared six consumer wearables—including WHOOP 3.0—with reference measurements for sleep, heart rate, and HRV in healthy adults. (PubMed)	Independent-evidence qualification. The research supports measurement validity under the tested conditions, but it validates a specific device generation and does not prove every downstream "recovery" recommendation or performance outcome.
WHOOP	Reddit, r/whoop — long-term user discussion	2024 thread	WHOOP users	Reactions were mixed. One user defended WHOOP's data presentation, while another concluded, "After 700 days: never whoop again." A third argued that its value was the insight derived from the data rather than perfect sensor accuracy. (Reddit)	Consumer trust is conditional. Athlete ownership can stimulate trial and credibility, but long-term trust remains dependent on price, measurement consistency, and perceived usefulness.

Appendix C. Reliant Recovery Water Coding Artifacts

Case	Source	Date	Speaker (Account)	Direct Quote or Content Summary	Theme

Reliant Recovery Water	*Rolling Stone* interview, preserved in contemporaneous reporting	Aug. 2015	Russell Wilson	Referring to the NFC Championship game, Wilson said: “I banged my head during the Packers game in the playoffs, and the next day I was fine… It was the water.” (KING 5 News)	Causal medical implication. Wilson moved beyond saying the drink aided ordinary hydration or recovery and appeared to attribute neurological recovery to the product.
Reliant Recovery Water	X/Twitter — original Wilson post	Aug. 26, 2015	@DangeRussWilson	“I believe @Recovery_Water helped prevent me from getting a concussion based on a bad hit! #NanoBubbles” (NBC Sports)	Investor claim amplified through social media. The statement was especially consequential because Wilson had an ownership interest and was speaking directly to fans.
Reliant Recovery Water	Post-practice media clarification	Aug. 27, 2015	Russell Wilson	Wilson said he had not actually suffered a concussion but still believed consistently drinking the water might have helped prevent one. (ESPN)	Claim modification without full withdrawal. He changed the claim from recovery after injury to prevention, but both versions still suggested an unsupported medical effect.

Reliant Recovery Water	*Rolling Stone* exchange, reproduced by *The Washington Post*	Aug. 2015	Mark Rodgers, Wilson's agent; Russell Wilson	Rodgers intervened: "Well, we're not saying we have real medical proof." Wilson nevertheless responded, "I know it works." (The Washington Post)	Visible governance failure. The agent recognized the evidentiary problem, yet apparently lacked the ability to prevent the athlete-investor from making the stronger claim.
Reliant Recovery Water	Official company statement supplied to media	Aug. 27–28, 2015	Reliant Recovery Water	Reliant initially described its process as potentially accelerating natural recovery and said it "may aid in physical recovery from injury." A later version removed the injury-recovery language and limited itself to "functional hydration." (Bleacher Report)	Corporate retreat. The changing wording suggests an effort to narrow the claim after Wilson's statements attracted scrutiny.

Reliant Recovery Water	Company spokeswoman's clarification	Aug. 27, 2015	Reliant spokesperson	The company said it had not known about Wilson's interview or brand statements before publication and redirected questions about his comments to his management. (The Washington Post)	Lack of message control. The equity relationship gave Wilson an authentic ownership story but apparently did not include effective preclearance of high-risk medical statements.
Reliant Recovery Water	Local television interview/report	Aug. 27–28, 2015	Dr. Emily Cooper	Cooper, a sports-medicine physician and lead author of a small study commissioned by the company, said Wilson's statements concerning head-injury recovery were not supported by the beverage research. (KING 5 News)	Internal scientific contradiction. Even a researcher associated with the product separated the available research from Wilson's concussion interpretation.

Reliant Recovery Water	Medical-expert reaction	Aug. 27, 2015	Chris Nowinski; Dr. Robert Stern and other concussion specialists	Nowinski characterized the claim as irresponsible and likely to confuse young athletes. Stern said the cited evidence did not establish a concussion treatment and warned that such statements could create false hope. (The Washington Post)	Public-health risk. Athlete credibility could encourage consumers to substitute testimonial belief for proper concussion evaluation and treatment.
Reliant Recovery Water	FDA warning cited by contemporaneous media	FDA warning issued in 2014; applied in coverage in Aug. 2015	U.S. Food and Drug Administration	The FDA's broader warning advised consumers to avoid products marketed to prevent, treat, or cure concussions because such claims lacked evidence of safety or effectiveness. (GeekWire)	Regulatory boundary. This was a general concussion-product warning, not evidence of a Reliant-specific FDA warning letter or enforcement order.
Reliant Recovery Water	Reddit, r/nfl	Aug. 28, 2015	Fans/users	Mocking reactions included "Impossible. Because Recovery Water" and the observation that another player was "at least… not hocking snake oil." (Reddit)	"Snake oil" framing. Public reaction interpreted the ownership-based testimonial as financially conflicted pseudoscience rather than authentic expertise.

Reliant Recovery Water	Reddit, r/nfl	Aug. 28, 2015	Fans/users	One commenter wrote, “Russ, just say that you… are invested in the drink.” Another said the pseudoscience damaged his credibility. (Reddit)	Disclosure does not cure overclaiming. Fans understood the investment relationship, but ownership made the medical claim appear more self-interested rather than more trustworthy.
Reliant Recovery Water	*The Washington Post* commentary	Aug. 27, 2015	Adam Kilgore	The article characterized the episode as “corny and dangerous” and argued that a prominent quarterback’s unsupported claim might influence young athletes’ concussion decisions. (The Washington Post)	Media legitimacy collapse. The controversy shifted the narrative from innovative recovery beverage to dangerous athlete-led misinformation.